

Who Will Get the Job? Hiring Practices and Inequalities in the Chilean Labour Market

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This article explores the ways in which recruitment and hiring practices can promote and sustain social inequality in a highly neoliberal country: Chile. The article analyses six steps in the selection process. It provides evidence of discriminatory practices in the job market by analysing employers' and recruiters' practices, hiring methods, and the experiences of professionals applying for a job. The research is based on 43 interviews with managers, human resources consultants, and candidates. It uses intersectional analysis to unpack dynamics of inequality in the selection processes in Chile. The findings demonstrate high levels of explicit and severe discrimination in the labour market.

Keywords: discrimination, hiring practices, inequality, intersectionality, recruitment, selection.

Research on hiring practices related to different dimensions of social inequality in Chile is notably scarce. In the context of a neoliberal culture and substantial levels of social inequality (Han, 2012; Richards, 2013), the growing significance of external selection services both in the private (e.g. headhunters) and public sector (e.g. Servicio Civil), and the use of 'objective' measures of candidate capabilities, this article explores the extent to which hiring practices contribute to (re)producing and legitimising inequality. The dominant workplace discourse highlights meritocracy, transparency and excellence, which this article seeks to problematise in order to uncover power mechanisms which produce and reproduce gender, class, sexuality, and ethnic/race inequalities in the labour market. The article unveils contradictions between theory and practice, problematises the naturalisation of social segregation, and demonstrates evidence of the multidimensionality of inequality which is manifested in discriminatory practices in the labour market. The article shows that beliefs and assumptions about gender, class, sexuality, and race/ethnicity have a tangible impact on which person is likely to be considered the most suitable candidate to fill a job opening. The article offers significant findings on discriminatory practices at all stages of the hiring process; it includes examples of overt discrimination, providing evidence of high levels of explicit and severe discrimination in the labour market in Chile.

There is extensive international evidence of disparity in the professional advancement of men and women. Gender schemas, which are hypotheses about what it means to be male or female, play a relevant role in expectations regarding professional competence:

men tend to be overrated and women underrated (Valian, 1998). In work settings, women usually avoid asking for recognition of the good work they do, and ask less for promotions and career upgrades than their male peers. There are societal factors that hold women back from asking for what they want. The gender gap in asking has cumulative effects on men's and women's salaries; women confront large financial losses by not negotiating their salaries (Babcock and Laschever, 2003, 2007). Gender stereotypes also influences evaluations in work settings (Heilman, 2012; Caleo, 2018). Gender discrimination in the workplace and gender bias at work still prevail (Bobbitt-Zeher, 2011; World Economic Forum, 2017; Verniers and Vala, 2018). To what extent are hiring practices in Chile gender biased? How do the intersections gender, class, race/ethnicity, sexuality, and age interact in the selection processes? Do Chileans discriminate, and how is this manifested in the labour market?

The article draws on two years of postdoctoral qualitative research exploring hiring practices by analysing employers' and recruiters' practices to select the best candidate, hiring methods, and the experiences of professionals applying for a job. The article analyses six steps in the selection process. It gives examples of the multidimensionality of inequality in personnel selection across these six steps, namely, developing the person specification, screening resumes, testing candidates, interviewing, making a decision, and completing the selection process. The research uses intersectional analysis, showing the extent to which the interplay of gender, class, race/ethnicity, and sexuality produces difference and privilege in the hiring process and its results. It provides evidence of discriminatory practices in the job market in Chile.

Inequalities in the Chilean Labour Market

Chile has enjoyed a relatively stable political and economic situation during the last few decades, becoming the development model for the rest of Latin America during the 1990s (Sehnbruch, 2006), and a member of the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) in January 2010. Although Chile can be considered a successful example of a new open market economy and has been called 'the Chilean miracle', its widespread inequality demonstrates an imbalance in the social distribution of its prosperity (Han, 2012; Richards, 2013). These inequalities are neither gender nor race neutral.

There are significant gender differences in the labour market, which are manifested in differentials in men's and women's participation rates, occupational segregation, salaries, and work trajectories (Undurraga and Barozet, 2015; ComunidadMujer, 2016; Mora and Blanco, 2018), ethnic/race salary gaps and disparities (Richards, 2013; Valenzuela, Toro, and Rojo-Mendoza, 2017), and class discrimination (Núñez and Gutiérrez, 2004). The female labour force participation rate is low compared to Chilean men, and to women in Latin America (Contreras and Plaza, 2010; Undurraga, 2013; ComunidadMujer, 2016). Moreover, women face higher risk of unemployment than men, particularly young women (INE [Instituto Nacional de Estadísticas], 2018). The social security system is based on individual savings, and labour market gaps mean that the opportunity and ability to pay contributions is both gender unequal and highly differentiated by class (Comisión Presidencial Pensiones, 2015; PNUD [Programa de las Naciones Unidas para el Desarrollo], 2010). In sum, one of Chile's main challenges is to reduce inequality across multiple spheres.

Therefore, this article takes an intersectional approach to exploring the extent to which hiring practices contribute to the (re)production of social inequality. Intersectionality is an analytical tool to understand multiple dimensions of inequality and the mechanisms of intersecting systems of power. It assumes that social categories are not autonomous and separate; they interact, overlap, intertwine, and relate to one another (Crenshaw, 1991; Lykke, 2010; Ferguson, 2013). The intersectional analytical approach is one of the main contributions of feminism (McCall, 2005). Using this approach means that gender, class, age, race/ethnicity, sexuality, among other social categories, interact and relate to each other within and across different contexts. These categories interact in such a way that one or more of them could become more predominant in particular contexts for certain individuals, generating privilege and difference. An intersectional approach helps to identify differences within and between social groups, and therefore provides an opportunity to make an insightful contribution that highlights persistent and multidimensional inequality, despite macro-economic success in Chile.

Methodology

This qualitative research was based on 43 semi-structured interviews across the three main groups in an employment selection process: (a) employers, managers, supervisors (those who initiate the hiring process), (b) HR staff, consultants, headhunters, specialists in personnel selection (those who carry out the hiring process), and (c) candidates who have recently participated in a selection process. Participants were professionals from across the private and public spheres, including representatives from the mining, banking, retail, government, and university sectors, among others. The sample contained 22 men and 21 women, of whom 39 were Chilean and four were of other nationalities. They were aged from 24 to 65 years old (on average 39 years old) and living in Santiago de Chile. To protect participants' anonymity, no individual or company names are identified – an ID number is used instead. Participants' quotes are included in the text to illustrate the argument, indicating their ID number, sex, age, sector, position, and profession.

Buchanan, Boddy, and McCalman (1988) advocate an opportunistic approach to fieldwork in organisations, utilising social ties to gain access. The researcher used personal connections to contact headhunters, job applicants and managers, who suggested potential interviewees (snowball technique with different entry points). Employers and headhunters described their most recent search process and how they decided that the selected candidate was the most suitable one for that post. Job applicants reported how they came to know about the job they are currently employed in or applying for, and their experiences during their most recent selection process. All the interviewees participated in different selection processes. The interviews were carried out between January and June 2012, and lasted from 35 minutes to one and a half hours. All the interviews were recorded and fully transcribed as a verbatim transcription. Atlas.ti software was used to support qualitative interview data analysis.

Recruitment and Selection

Hiring a new employee involves a recruitment process by which applicants are sought, and a selection process by which applicants are sorted according to their knowledge, skills, and abilities for the post.

In recent decades, recruitment strategies have changed and diversified. Newspaper advertising is becoming less frequent, while use of the Internet is increasing. More organisations announce jobs through their website, or use specialised online recruiting companies to attract candidates. Likewise, professionals use LinkedIn, Facebook and other social networks as a way of learning about new job openings and to promote themselves in the job market. The increased use of the Internet for recruitment and selection is an international trend (Parry and Wilson, 2009; Hoek, O’Kane, and McCracken, 2016).

In Chile, the use of the Internet to attract candidates is associated with large-scale searches for professional and technical positions, but is less frequently used to attract high-end managers. Recruiters taking part in this study reported receiving too many resumes, with few submitting candidates suitable for top positions. Successful resumes usually emanated from referees and networks. According to participants, this is because they can access candidates ‘they can trust’ this way. Thus, the use of networks and ‘friends of friends’ is an important way of finding out about job offers and of accessing employers. This study found that in the Chilean labour market networks can facilitate finding candidates with the appropriate skills, knowledge, and socio-economic background. In Bourdieu’s terms (Bourdieu, 1986), referees will bring candidates with similar social capital. Therefore, notwithstanding the increasing significance of the Internet to advertise jobs and candidates, personal networks and social ties (social capital) remain crucial to identifying job opportunities and accessing jobs (Granovetter, 1974). This could be problematic as it allows room for classism.

Organisations want to show professionalism in the selection process to attract job applicants, while employment consultancies seek actively to legitimise professionalism in searches for executive-level roles (Beaverstock, Faulconbridge, and Hall, 2010). Consequently, in Chile, employers and recruiters often make an effort to highlight the existence of a professional system with objective and standardised methods implemented by experts. This has led to the establishment of selection processes carried out by psychologists who apply tools such as psychological tests and interviews to applicants as standard practice. The aim is to create a ‘professionalised’ process which is distinguishable from processes characterised by informality and prior familiarity between the employer and potential candidates. They claim to use an effective and transparent process to find candidates of excellence, but the reality is often contradictory. Recruiters claim that the process, staff, and tools used to assure reliability and meritocracy are central to a process aimed at selecting the best applicants from the applicant pool. For example, an HR Selection Manager of a retail company observed:

My role is to choose and hire the best talents in the market, to have a transparent process, with opportunities for internal people as well; to have a professional selection process [...] The interviews are conducted by psychologists. They are well-prepared by external entities; they apply tests, conduct interviews assessing competencies, and they prepare psycho-labour evaluations and reports that have validity and professional support. (ID10, Female, 32 years old, psychologist)

The article will now seek to unpack this discourse by means of exploring the different stages of the selection process and the practices that sustain them.

Developing the Person Specification

The first step of the hiring process is to define the job description (main responsibilities of the post) and the person specification (essential and desirable criteria). According to participants, the person specification is discussed between the selection specialist and the person in charge of the hiring process (e.g. the manager or supervisor). As this HR consultant observed:

In terms of methodology, what we do is to agree the job profile with the client, in detail. I do that personally, with the person in charge, the boss [*el jefe responsable*], because I have to know him. In addition, I have to understand his style, the organisational culture of the department and the company. (ID7, Female, 44 years old, business administrator)

It is relevant to keep a 'gender lens' in mind (Acker, 2006). West and Zimmerman (1987) argue that gender is embedded in everyday interaction; gender emerges from social institutions and social intercourse. They point out that 'doing gender' is unavoidable: people 'do gender' in everyday interactions, maintaining, (re)producing and legitimating ways of organising social life. In Spanish, language is intrinsically gendered, as it is noticeable when it is masculine or feminine. In this research, most participants searching for hierarchical positions refer to *el gerente* as a male manager, and when they verbally speak about boss they say *el jefe*, which refers to a male boss. For example, the quote above (ID7) assumes that the boss is a man, which has a negative impact on women's access to top positions (Tienari et al., 2013). The concept of homosociality has been used to describe men's preference for other men, and to understand new forms of gendering in organisations and recruiting (Holgersson, 2013). Therefore, the decision-making process and access to power are gendered.

The essential requirements of the person specification generally outline candidates' required qualifications and training, skills and knowledge, and job experience, among other factors. Within desirable characteristics, most recruiters detail university education, language skills, postgraduate specialisation, and salary expectations. However, based on the testimony of most participants, other filters are also used to find the best match, such as gender, marital status, nationality, school, and home address. These 'other criteria' are linked to different factors, which, taken together, define the identity of the candidate. The interaction of multiple dimensions of identity in a particular context may affect which person is considered to be the best candidate. Even more problematic is the fact that these social categories are valued depending on who is selecting and on whose behalf, according to their beliefs and prejudices. This practice creates and maintains social inequality, stratification and exclusion. This research found that social inequalities are (re)produced when candidates are chosen or rejected based on social categories. As this HR consultant from a dot-com recruitment company reported, their clients stipulate what/who they are looking for – including discriminatory variables:

Nowadays the client tells you, I mean, if they want someone from x school, y university, and living in z neighbourhood, they tell you. [...] If it is a must or if they don't tell you, suddenly they don't choose any candidate who is not like the client. In multinational companies it is a bit different. They are more open to hiring, but in Chilean companies, my experience at least, is that they look for two professions, two universities, and about five schools. (ID36, Female, 34 years old, recruiter, business administrator)

Employers also refer to hard skills (technical and teachable abilities) and soft skills (personal and interpersonal qualities) within the person specification. However, within these soft skills there is ambiguity. Recruiters said that some employers describe these soft skills with words such as 'trustworthy' and 'seniority' to relate to social poise, non-verbal communication, and attitude, social contacts, or other euphemisms which imply filtering by class, ethnicity, and gender. Race and cultural hierarchies have shaped social relations in Chile (Richards, 2013). As this HR consultant stated:

In general, they ask you for a 'good profile', and that has a subtext: social and racial. The subtext is white, not brown nor black... whiter. (ID1, Female, 36 years old, psychologist)

Richards (2013) argues that neoliberal economic policies in Chile extended the legacy of racism and inequality, consolidating traditional racial ideas and hierarchies. Her research on conflicts between Mapuche indigenous people and state and private actors finds systemic racism in the context of neoliberal multiculturalism in southern Chile. She also explores the intersections of race, class, and gender showing power differences and inequalities among Chilean women (Richards, 2004). Regarding work settings, a study by the Centro de Estudios de Opinión Ciudadana (CEOC, The Citizen Opinion Studies Center) (CEOC, 2009) exploring discriminatory attitudes in Chile found that 70.7 percent of respondents believe that a Mapuche surname can be detrimental to entry into the labour market or getting on the career ladder; instead, employers prefer someone white. Therefore, it is pertinent to ask: to what extent are characteristics such as race/ethnicity, class, nationality, sexuality and gender relevant to whether one is accepted or rejected for a job?

Screening Resumes

What are employers and recruiters looking for when they screen resumes in Chile? The process starts by analysing resumes according to the person specification, selecting those that comply with the essential requirements and then those registering desirable characteristics. However, as discussed in the previous section, there are other factors that inform the hiring process. One that is common is selection by university attended. In Chile, access to the top universities is associated with educational background, which is related to familial socio-economic status. Therefore, filtering by university could also mean by class. For instance, candidates having attended some universities that are not highly ranked academically are still well positioned in the labour market because of the social networks they imply, namely that they are expensive universities which middle- or upper-class students attend. Other criteria relevant for the selection process include language skills, school, extracurricular activities, family, and neighbourhood. These aspects can act as filters that do not directly relate to the job profile, mitigating the possibility of accessing a job based purely on merit. The following HR staff explained:

We still mainly look for engineers and business administrators, but not many people from [x university] anymore because of the 'person-profile'. We don't find it there. [Person-profile] relates to a middle-upper socio-economic level. We look at the school where the candidate studied, and their home address. When we interview them we look at their networks [...] we ask where are your friends from, what sort of activities/hobbies do you like. So

then if they say, 'I go out with my friends from the beach because I spent the summers here or there', or 'I belong to x club' or 'I play football in x team', then you can locate people. Also, many people are the friend of a friend, which has that built-in social filter as they belong to the same circle. (ID10, Female, 32 years old, retail, HR Selection Manager, psychologist)

This quote highlights the relevance of social and cultural capital (Bourdieu, 1986) in accessing jobs. As previously described, Chilean society has significant social inequalities and is highly segregated. If an employment selection process follows this segregation by replicating specific characteristics likely to be found in a specific group within selection criteria, social inequalities are reproduced. As an example, this psychologist from a dot-com recruiter company explained how the job market works for her:

Top companies discriminate; to start with they ask for languages and that's a filter of social class. Then we filter by district, by neighbourhood. If the employer is [x retail], they say that [x retail's boss] doesn't hire anyone who is not blonde [white]. I've heard that, I cannot confirm it, it's horrible, it is unfair [...] They [employers] ask about the family, they are interested in the surname; they hope to find someone in common and ideally to be able to ring someone to have a reference and if they know each other, they get hired. They discriminate by socio-cultural profile, by colour. I got this job because I am blonde and Argentinean, I am sure. I didn't have this sort of work experience. I used to work as a therapist. (ID37, Female, 38 years old, dot-com recruiter, Selection Vice-manager, psychologist)

These examples show that social categories such as race/ethnicity, class, nationality, and the area where the candidate lives can have a significant impact on the hiring process. Here, multiple dimensions of inequality produce difference, discriminating against those who do not comply with the hegemonic profile of privileged groups.

Testing Candidates

Following the screening and selection of resumes, the most common way of assessing candidates in Chile is through a psycho-labour evaluation, which can include psychometric tests, projective tests, intelligence and specific skills tests, competency-based interviews, group interviews and telephone interviews. Checking references is also commonplace. This recruiter indicated how they assess candidates for external clients:

We carry out competency-based interviews, apply psychometric tests, projective tests, and specific skills tests depending on the job profile. We check references and present a shortlist of candidates. (ID41, Female, 30 years old, psychologist)

Psychologists are perceived to be specialists in assessing candidates. They 'certify' the validity, objectivity, and professionalism of the process, through being an external and qualified expert using relevant tools to elicit their results.

The use of psychological testing for selection purposes has been debated, particularly the predictive value of ability and personality tests (Arthur, Woehr, and Graziano, 2001; Carless, 2009). Findings show that conscientiousness and general mental ability are valid predictors of job performance (Salgado et al., 2003; Barros et al., 2014), while

personality testing based on projective methods is not supported by evidence (Pereira, Primi, and Cobêro, 2003). In this study, the psychological tests most frequently mentioned by participants are Zullinger (Z), Lüscher ('test of colours'), the person under the rain, the Rorschach test, and in some cases, psychologists also apply graphology. All of them are projective tests. This pool of tests is similar to that reported by other Chilean studies (Barros, 2011). Most projective techniques were created for clinical assessment rather than for personnel selection (Pereira, Primi, and Cobêro, 2003), and there is controversy surrounding the effective use of projective techniques even in the clinical practice (Garb et al., 2002). This raises concerns about the accuracy of using projective tests for selection purposes and their ability to predict job performance.

HR consultants and managers advocate the use of psychological tests to identify personality characteristics that match with the soft skills of the person specification, as well as to detect any mental health issue or pathology that could interfere with a good performance in post. The consultants also report the use of intelligence (IQ test) and behavioural tests. However, from applicants' perspective, this practice could be problematic. As this professional 44-year-old explained:

They asked me to fill in all sort of tests that I've never seen before, very long and dense, it took me about four hours [...] I really had a headache, and came out feeling dizzy. (ID22, Male, IT company, engineer)

Discrimination on the grounds of mental health issues in the job market is problematic. If a psychological test indicates that a candidate has a potential mental health issue, they should not be treated unfavourably because of their mental health condition.

International companies participating in this study did not use psychological tests in their selection process, whereas their use is commonplace in national organisations across different sectors. The type of job also determines the nature of the test applied – candidates for senior positions such as high-level managers usually do not participate in psychometric tests. Instead, they are assessed via interviews, and their work experience is considered sufficient proof of their qualities.

This research found that for most employers and recruiters (and many candidates as well), the use of psychological tests is assumed to assure an objective and professional procedure, carried out by experts (psychologists). They also believe that, through tests, they can promote meritocracy, as the hiring results would be based on tests that assess hard and soft skills rather than biography. However, the use of psychological testing is very concerning for a variety of reasons, including: (a) the accuracy of the tests used for predicting job performance is questionable; (b) applicants may be in a vulnerable position when they are clinically assessed for hiring purposes; (c) if a test indicates that a candidate has a potential mental health issue, they should not be discriminated against on these grounds; and (d) the use of such tests raises serious concerns around privacy and data protection. Therefore, the widespread practice in Chile of using psychological tests during personnel selection is debatable.

Interviewing

The use of interviews in personnel selection is an international practice. Even though there is no standard format, time limit, type of questions, or number of interviews common to selection processes throughout organisations in Chile, the interview is the predominant way of choosing the successful candidate.

Who Will Get the Job?

Selectors try to assess applicants' fit with the recruiting organisation. This research explored employers' and recruiters' beliefs around candidates' qualities that make them the 'right choice' for an organisation. It has found that an important priority for Chilean recruiters is to ensure that the personal characteristics of the applicant correspond with the characteristics of the organisation, in terms of values, cultural affinity, interests and expectations. For example, this psychologist emphasised the importance of matching the organisation's and candidate's values:

First, a good candidate is someone who meets the person specification in the job. Second, someone who has the level of motivation required. Third, the candidate must meet the organisational values, where the company stresses values, and embrace those values. For example, here we have four values that we have to measure – that is something the organisation asks. So if someone is low in any of those values, they are rejected. (ID4, Male, 34 years old, health organisation)

Often employers and recruiters also try to identify the hobbies and other personal information of the applicant. This is problematic as it leaves space for assumptions, prejudices, and attributions based on biography. The following example from an employer illustrates this type of personal question being posed in a job interview:

I ask if they have a partner, and if it says married in the resume, I ask with whom they are married, how many children they have, their ages and the school they go to, and hobbies. For example, for me it is very important to ask about hobbies and I will tell you why. It tells me about someone who has other interests, anything, sports, reading, music or playing instruments, learning languages, going to art museums, etc. It tells me about people who are intellectually active and that is attractive. (ID17, Female, 48 years old, entrepreneur association, engineer)

From applicants' perspective, this could be an unpleasant experience. It highlights unequal power relationships, and the vulnerable position of candidates. As this professional said:

I felt bad in an interview when the HR Manager asked me many personal questions, about my private life, what I do during the weekend, what sort of things I like to do. Far beyond the job, and I think that shows a lack of respect. (ID38, Female, 43 years old, mining, psychologist)

Even though there is increasing awareness of, and action to tackle, the problem of discrimination in Chile, employers, recruiters and job candidates often legitimate discriminatory practices in the selection process. I shall present various examples of discrimination in job interviews, to reflect on the multidimensionality of inequality and the extent to which the interplay of different social categories produces difference and privilege in the labour market. The experience of a 52-year-old male candidate follows:

To be honest, they really wanted to know if I have contacts. They asked me if I knew people. [...] Well, let's say that I know a lot of people. I tried to present myself in a positive light [...] First, they asked me about my family, where I used to work before, and they took the information they wanted

from there. I would say that what I studied didn't matter at all [...] they hired me because I went to a private school, perhaps because I live in a certain neighbourhood in Santiago. Besides, as I used to work as a stockbroker, I relate to certain people... I believe they chose me because of that, nothing else. (ID31, bank, sales agent)

This example clearly emphasises class inequalities when applying for a job. Social networks, private education, family composition, and neighbourhood were indicators of compliance with the socio-economic-cultural background of the applicant the employer sought.

Gender bias exists in the hiring process. Assumptions about family life and care for children intersect with age mainly in the case of women (Undurraga, 2018). For example, the fact of being a young married woman could be a barrier to entry into the job market, yet the interaction of similar social categories in a male candidate has a different result. This study found that a man being married is considered by employers to be a positive factor, with married status indicating stability, maturity, and family values. Likewise, elsewhere, for men, having a wife and children is perceived as a sign of normality and stability, and as an asset (Holgersson, 2013; Tienari et al., 2013). Marital status is a social category that includes or excludes candidates. It emerges and interacts with gender, age, sexuality, and class.

These beliefs about married people not only exclude single applicants but also people who identify as LGBTQ+, who face widespread discrimination in Chile – for example, gay marriage is not legally recognised. Heterosexuality facilitates entering the labour market, while homosexuality could be detrimental. This illustrates the heteronormativity of Chilean society.

Despite the control that dedicated recruitment companies have over elite labour recruitment processes (Faulconbridge et al., 2009; Tienari et al., 2013), some recruiters elude their responsibility while discriminating, arguing that they do it because of the clients' needs or for the candidate. For example, this HR consultant avoids presenting candidates 'out of the norm' in order to please the client, to respond to their organisational culture, and to avoid causing 'suffering' to gay candidates who could enter homophobic workplaces. As she commented:

If an avowed homosexual comes here, and the culture of the company would not be able to tolerate this, I filter it. Well, first because he will have a bad experience in the interview. Second, I'll give him false expectation that he can apply to a place where the organisational culture won't be able to absorb him. (ID7, Female, 44 years old, business administrator)

This example is also problematic as she takes the decision on behalf of others (applicant, organisation). In other cases, an elderly single man could be perceived as a gay person, providing a potential reason for non-selection. Gender, sexuality, and marital status are also correlated with age – not too old but not too young. As this manager from a technology company stated:

I look at the age, not too young. I want people with experience. In fact, I just hired the finance manager who is 52 years old. I aim for candidates with at least five years of experience, because when they are too young it means more turnover and replacements. They arrive and in a couple of months they want to earn more, and the market is offering alternatives, so

they leave. That's why I look for mature people, responsible, with a family, who make changes in a more conscious way. (ID21, Female, 48 years old, engineer)

After interviewing preselected candidates, HR members suggest a shortlist of candidates (usually three to five) to the manager, who will interview them and decide on the chosen applicant.

Making a Decision

Personnel selection necessarily implies a process of including and excluding applicants. Yet, this article has discussed problematic criteria through which candidates are selected, such as basing decisions on characteristics related to identity – gender, sexuality, marital status, age, race/ethnicity, among others. These social categories interact, producing difference and privilege in the labour market. This section reflects on the assumptions underpinning the decision-making processes engaged in by employers to identify the desired applicant. This article suggests that, for employers, candidate homogeneity turns out to be an asset, segregation becomes natural, and inequality legitimated. Some managers and recruiters believe that homogeneity facilitates social interaction, adaptation to the existing group and the organisation, thereby helping to avoid conflict and confrontation between staff. I hypothesise that this is based on the fear of 'the other', the unknown, and the possibility of the loss of power. Homophily – the preference to be with peers – is a useful concept for this tendency to associate with people whom one perceives as like to oneself. This results in 'homosocial reproduction' – in other words, selecting people who comply with certain social criteria (Holgersson, 2013). For example, this manager desired a homogeneous team:

I: When you look at the candidate's resume, what is important for you to decide that you will interview that person?

P: First, the school. Traditional [private] schools and a good university, [...] non-academic activities, such as sports, exchange programmes, and so on, so that person could be like the people who work here. To be honest, this is a bank where the employees' profile in the commercial area is quite homogeneous [...] To keep it like that [...] we could build a good working group, a team and an enjoyable interaction. (ID15, Male, 38 years old, bank, commercial manager)

Chileans tend to interact with others who are similar. Educational and socio-spatial segregation deter the interaction of people from different backgrounds (Valenzuela, Bellei, and de Los Ríos, 2014; Borsdorf, Hildalgo, and Vidal-Koppmann, 2016); segregation then becomes naturalised. Although there is an incipient awareness concerning diversity, the norm is to relate within homogeneous groups. The idea that diversity of opinions and backgrounds could enrich the interaction and perspectives is not put into practice, yet. Employers tend to hire applicants like them whom they can 'trust'; someone with whom they can identify and find something in common. There is preference for the known rather than the unknown. In this context, difference is perceived as a challenge.

As discussed earlier, networks and contacts are important for enabling the exchange of information about available job opportunities. In this system, if a candidate knows

someone within the company, that candidate has more opportunity to jump ahead in the queue of other potential employees. Reciprocity, friendship, and exchange of favours (also known as *pituto* in Chilean Spanish) are part of Chilean social life (Barozet, 2006). As a university director explained:

In general, Chile is still a country of *pitutos*. It is difficult not to trust most in the referred candidate. And, you know – I have experienced this – that many job offers are fake. They are posted in the papers, but the chosen ones are already preselected. Let's say, if there is a hiring process and the vice-chancellor of a university tells me: 'I have a candidate for you'. Send me that person. That's it. Over. (ID16, Male, 50 years old, university)

These practices clearly contradict the idea of a transparent process which promotes meritocracy, objectivity, and the professionalisation of the hiring process. As long as 'other criteria', preference for homogeneity, and the 'known' are instrumental to decision-making around the best candidate, meritocracy will remain an illusion.

Finishing the Selection Process

How does the selection process end? The employer decides on the selected candidate, following which the two parties agree on the salary and the starting date. Those hired obviously know that they were selected. However, candidates who are not shortlisted rarely receive a response from recruiters. Most participants stated that they usually do not receive a conclusive answer in which they are informed of the reasons why they were not chosen. In many cases, they eventually assume they were not selected as a result of not receiving further contact from the employer. As this candidate explained:

I went to an interview with [x ministry], but they didn't call me again. After a while, I got to know through someone else that they might want me for another area within the ministry, but they never told me. So I suppose they don't have the time or the energy to be calling every 'no' candidate; though, that would be positive for me. (ID32, Female, 24 years old, government, political scientist)

If they do receive an answer, it is a standard and short reply thanking the candidate for their interest in the company and for participating in the selection process, with no further feedback on the decision. A HR specialist from a bank stated:

We send an answer but not the motive of the result. We cannot. Think that we are 13,000 employees, this is a huge company, and we assess everything here. It's already enough. We don't have time. (ID6, Female, 28 years old, psychologist)

That applicants neither receive feedback on their performance nor comments about their psychological tests is problematic. The prevailing logic prioritises 'customer-service' to the client of the HR recruitment agency. In other words, the 'owner' of the results is the employer. Despite job applicants taking psychological tests, they are not treated as patients who have a right or opportunity to obtain the results of their examination. As applicants do not know their testing results, they cannot object to hiring decisions

referring to these tests. I would say that this practice entails a clear lack of respect and transparency to candidates.

These practices show unbalanced power relationships and social inequalities, both among applicants, and between candidates and employers/recruiters. In short, this research has shown that in many cases pervasive discrimination exists in the job market.

Conclusion

Research on personnel selection related to social inequality in Chile is notably scarce. This article contributes to filling that gap by providing evidence of discriminatory practices within the labour market, showing how social categories interact to (re)produce privilege and difference when professionals apply for a job. The article has presented evidence on recruitment and selection practices in the Chilean labour market. It has analysed six phases in the evaluation process: developing the person specification, screening resumes, testing candidates, interviewing, making a decision, and finishing the selection process. Despite the specificity of the data collected, the results illuminate cross-cultural ways of performing gender in organisations and how minorities' access to the labour market is hindered. The article, however, also has some limitations: (a) it does not address hiring practices outside the professional sphere; (b) it does not address discrimination on the grounds of disability. These topics could be explored in future research.

Employers emphasise that they carry out a professional and transparent selection process to promote meritocracy and reward excellence. They sustain this belief by adhering to a selection system that relies on qualified experts (psychologists) who in turn apply objective tools (psychometric tests), ostensibly to choose the best talents of the market (meritocracy). The article has considered to what extent theory and practice are in line with each other. Regrettably, it demonstrates that from the very beginning of the selection process 'other criteria' influence the search. These include different factors that contribute to defining the identity of the candidate. In doing so, gender, class, race/ethnicity, age, sexuality, nationality, marital status, home address, school, university, and references, among others, become relevant characteristics. This article argues that social inequalities are (re)produced when candidates are chosen or rejected based on social criteria, that hiring practices are gender-biased, and that various forms of discrimination exist throughout the selection process. These experiences illustrate the racial, gendered and cultural hierarchies which shape social relations in Chile.

In recent decades, the Internet and social networks have become popular means to advertise jobs and for candidates to profile themselves. Yet social ties remain fundamental to accessing jobs. The Chilean labour market still privileges friendship ties and *pituto* in hiring decision-making processes. I have suggested that homogeneity is an asset. Prejudice around those seen as 'the other' results in individuals with similar characteristics becoming isolated within elite groups whose members share a largely homogeneous profile, meaning that segregation between different groups becomes the norm and inequalities legitimated. Homosociability also contributes to reproduction of the gender order.

Despite the national practice of using projective tests for personnel selection, evidence of its usefulness in predicting job performance is questionable. Yet psychologists emphasise the validity, objectivity, and professionalism of the selection process which is achieved through the tests they administer and their own credentials. Discrimination on the grounds of mental health issues is problematic. Candidates are exposed to

long evaluations including private matters and personal questions, but receive neither feedback on their performance nor the results of their psychometric tests. The logic of customer service prevails – the recruiter provides services to their client (the employer), who therefore exclusively owns the results. The candidate is left uninformed about the outcome of the application process, and with a lack of clarity around their right to the information obtained about them. The use of these tests also raises concerns around privacy and data protection. Therefore, the use of psychological tests for hiring purposes is debatable.

Unmasking how the selection process is shaped by the interaction of social categories offers the potential to raise awareness of discriminatory practices. It can also serve as a catalyst for change by encouraging employers and recruitment agencies to widen the pool of suitable candidates, regardless of their identity. The ultimate aim would be to translate equality, meritocracy, and transparency from the discourse level into everyday practices in organisations. More research and further legal and regulatory measures focused on equal treatment and anti-discrimination in recruitment are also needed to enhance meritocracy and ensure fair hiring results.

In sum, hiring practices that legitimise social categories as relevant criteria for the selection of the best person for the job jeopardise meritocracy and (re)produce social inequality. The examples illustrated in this article signal that much remains to be done to develop equity and respect for others within the Chilean labour market, particularly concerning private life, time use, and the mainstreaming of selection according to the candidates' skills and knowledge related to the job rather than 'extra' criteria imposed by the hegemonic dominant groups. Reflecting on our assumptions and beliefs about oneself and others is a crucial driver for change. Increasing awareness of the inappropriate nature of asking personal questions of job applicants, and discriminating on the grounds of any social category is a critical first step to changing these aberrant practices that reinforce unequal power relations and hamper social equality in the labour market.

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